

Modem

The modem is the key to accessing the internet, as we all know. Basically, modems modulate an analog carrier signal to encode and decode digital information. What you may not know though is that while cable and DSL modems are the most popular types of modem used for accessing information on the



internet, modems can actually also be used to transmit any kind of analog signals. Radio modems, for example, send data frames over microwave radio links while optical modems use optic fibers for sharing of data.

Modems came into existence around the 1960s when they were primarily used to communicate data between terminals and a host computer. In those times, they had a mind-bogglingly slow speed of 300 bits per second – to put it into perspective, an average movie download of 700MB would take over 20 days to complete! Now, compare that to the optical modems mentioned above which can transmit an incredible billion bits per second through the use of undersea optic fibers. While you may think that everyone would surely have shifted to these advanced optical modems by now, AOL in its 2012 annual report actually showed that it still collects around \$700 million in fees from dial-up users. In India too, the dial-up modem continues to remain popular in rural areas where cable and optical modems are yet to become a reality.

Mouse

We work with the mouse every day without even giving a thought to where it came from, when in reality it has come to define much of the way in which we use a computer.

Defined simply as a ‘pointing’ device, it was Douglas Engalbart who created the first mouse prototype in 1963. However, the actual ball-mouse that we’re all familiar with was only created later in 1972 by Bill English. Essentially created so that people could easily navigate through software without remembering keyboard shortcuts, the humble mouse too had its share of detractors with computer columnist, John Dvorak writing in 1984, “There is no evidence that people want to use these things.”